

Connecting^{the} Masses

BitTorrent has overshadowed every other P2P network to become the world's bandwidth hog—much to the chagrin of ISPs and anti-piracy activists. It's not all bad though... here's everything you need to know about BitTorrent

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More than one of every three bits of data on the Net is using the BitTorrent protocol, meaning that at least one third of all Internet traffic can be attributed to P2P file sharing on the BitTorrent network. The only other bandwidth hog that comes close is the eDonkey network, again P2P. And about P2P in general, at any given point in time, between 50 and 90 per cent of data being transferred across the Net, globally, is being done so on P2P networks.

Don't misconstrue these numbers: the world is not using only BitTorrent clients for everything. The reality is, one person downloading from P2P networks will use more bandwidth than a hundred or even a thousand people just

browsing through sites. It's actually a case of minorities using the majority of the world's bandwidth, but there's no doubt that when talking about P2P, BitTorrent is the first thing people think of today—over 53 per cent of P2P users rely on it to find what they want.

What Is BitTorrent?

Bram Cohen, the man behind the BitTorrent protocol, first released it to the world in July 2001. Back then, everyone's pet problem was sharing large files—imagine wanting to distribute a Linux distro like Ubuntu (about 700 MB), hosting it on a site, and then millions of people trying to download it simultaneously... you guessed it: everyone would share the server's available bandwidth and get little or nothing. Instead, BitTorrent works by allowing all those downloading the same file to download chunks of it from each other as well.